



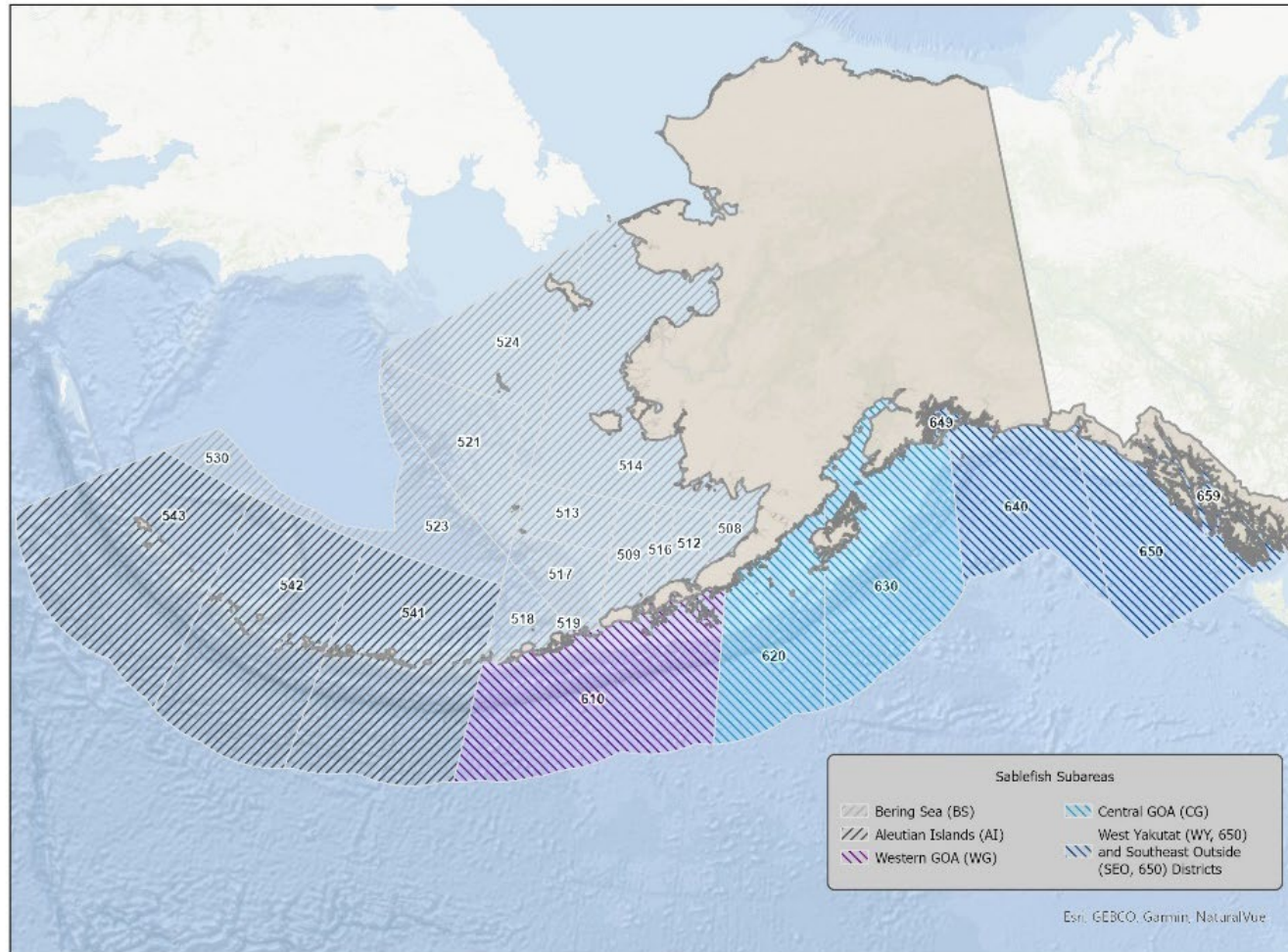
Alaska Sablefish Management Considerations

Sablefish Assessment CIE Review, June 2026

Sara Cleaver, North Pacific Fishery Management Council (NPFMC)



Federal Groundfish Management Areas & Fishery Management Plans (AK sablefish)



Gulf of Alaska (GOA) Groundfish FMP

Pollock, cod, flatfish, **sablefish**,
rockfish, etc.

Bering Sea/Aleutian Islands Groundfish (BSAI) FMP

Pollock, cod, flatfish, **sablefish**,
rockfish, etc.



Catch Limits / Biological Reference Points

In the North Pacific, catch limits are specified where: $TAC \leq ABC < OFL$

OFL (overfishing limit) is harvest limit associated with maximum sustainable yield (MSY).

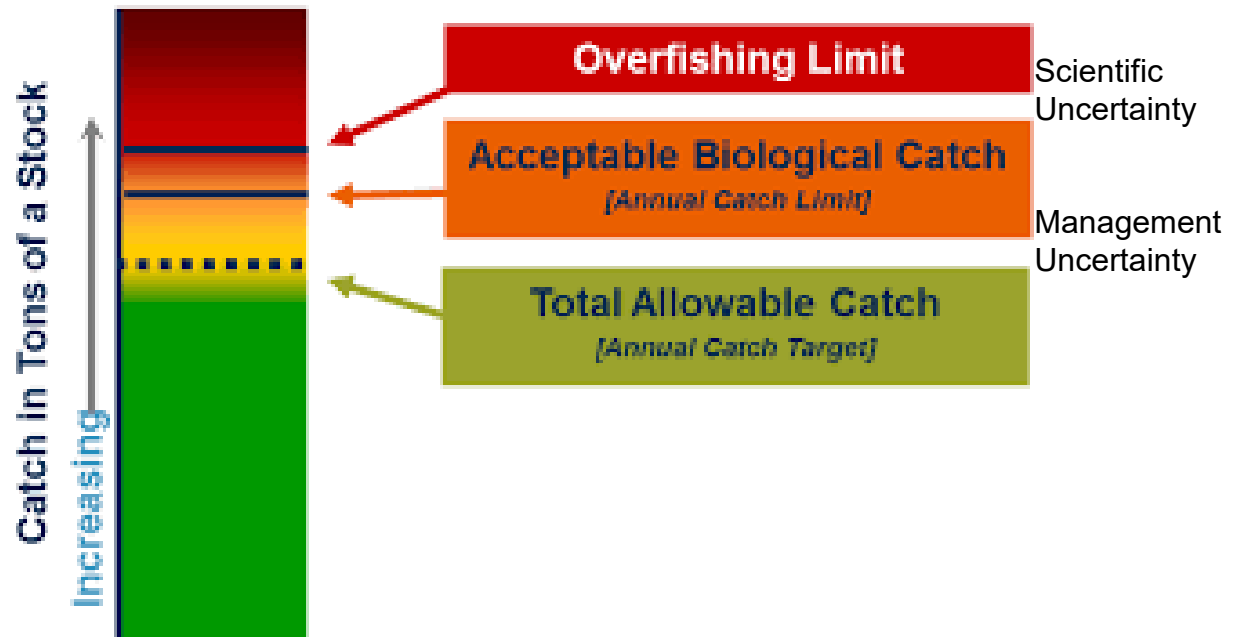
- *Functionally set by Scientific & Statistical Committee (SSC)*

ABC (acceptable biological catch) is the harvest limit that takes into account uncertainties in the assessment process (scientific uncertainty).

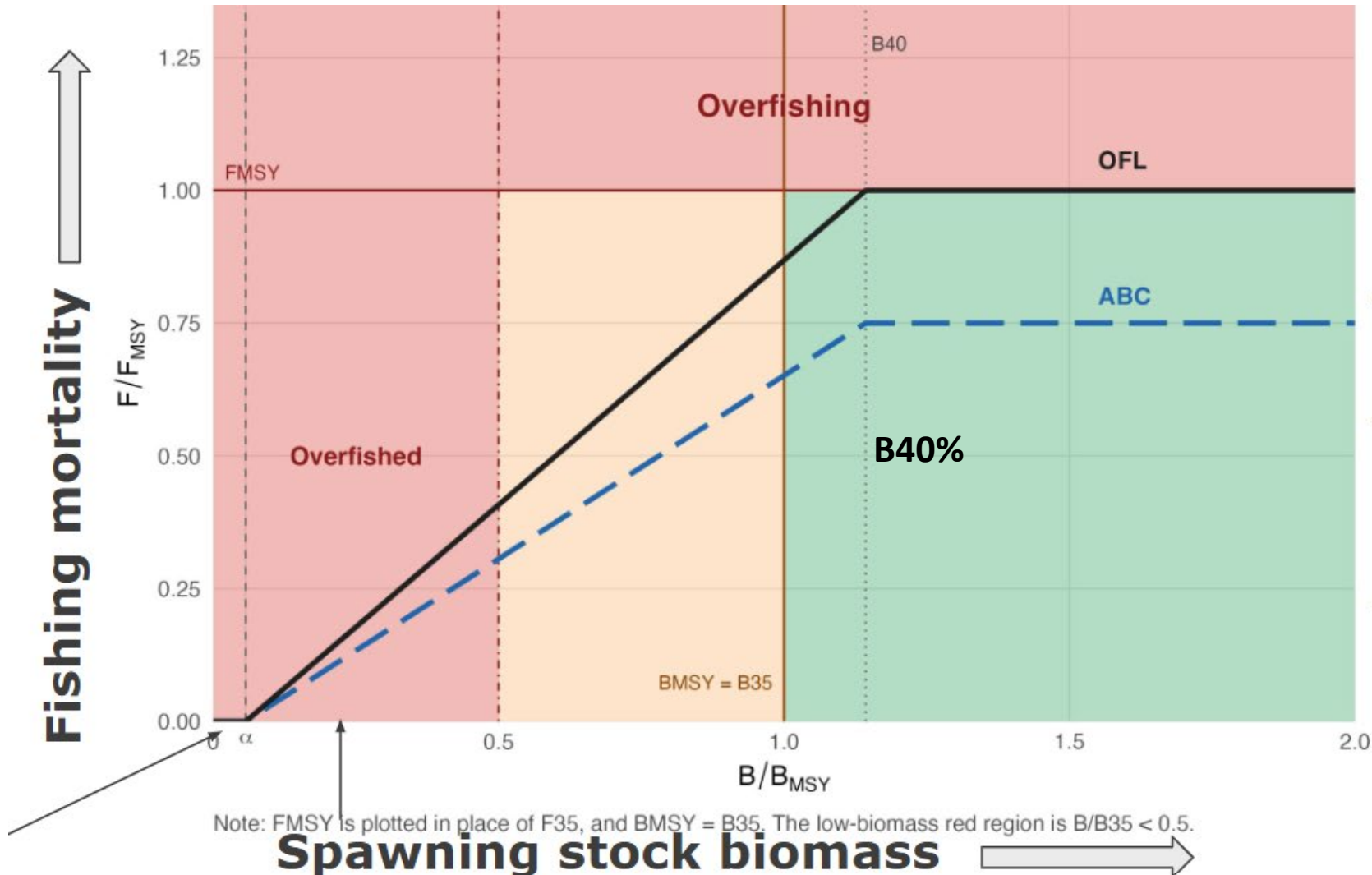
- *Functionally set by SSC*
- *ABC = annual catch limit*

TAC (total allowable catch) is the target that includes socioeconomic considerations and accounts for management uncertainty.

- *Groundfish: set by Council*



Sablefish OFL and ABC HCRs

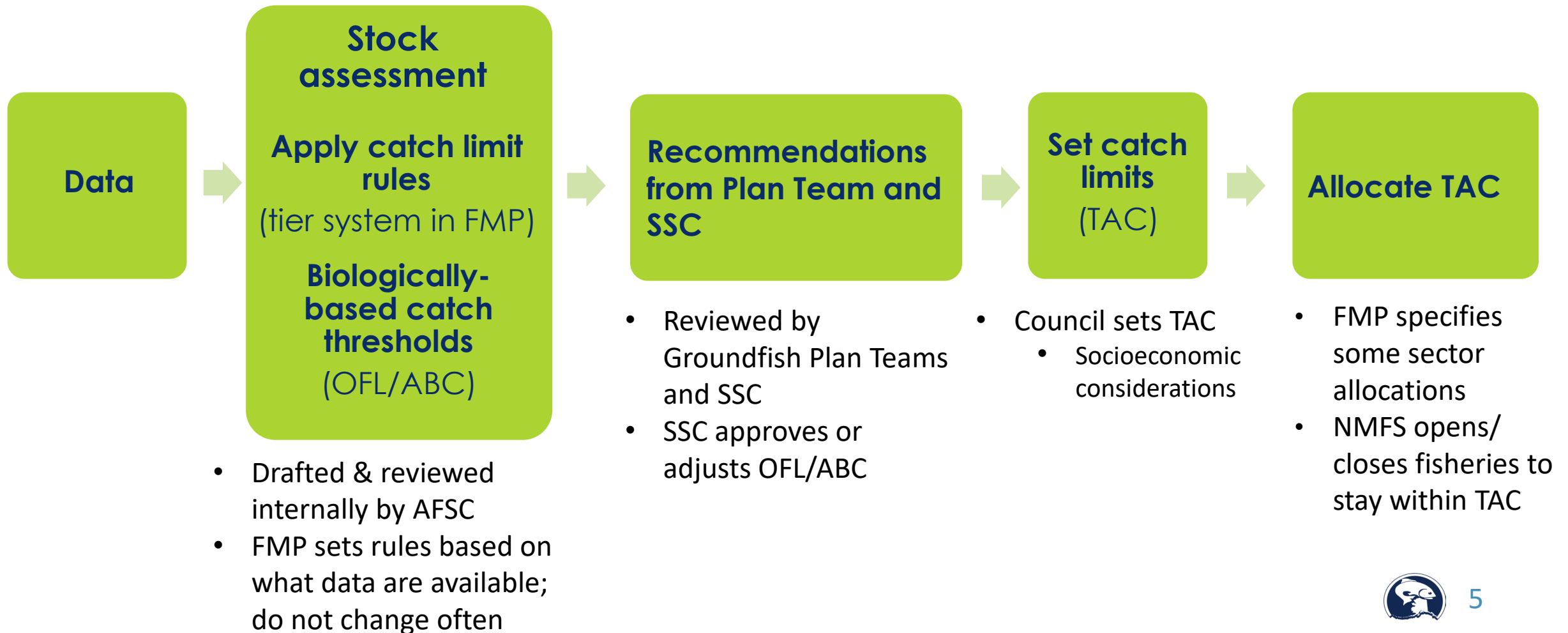


Status Quo Tier 3 OFL and ABC HCR

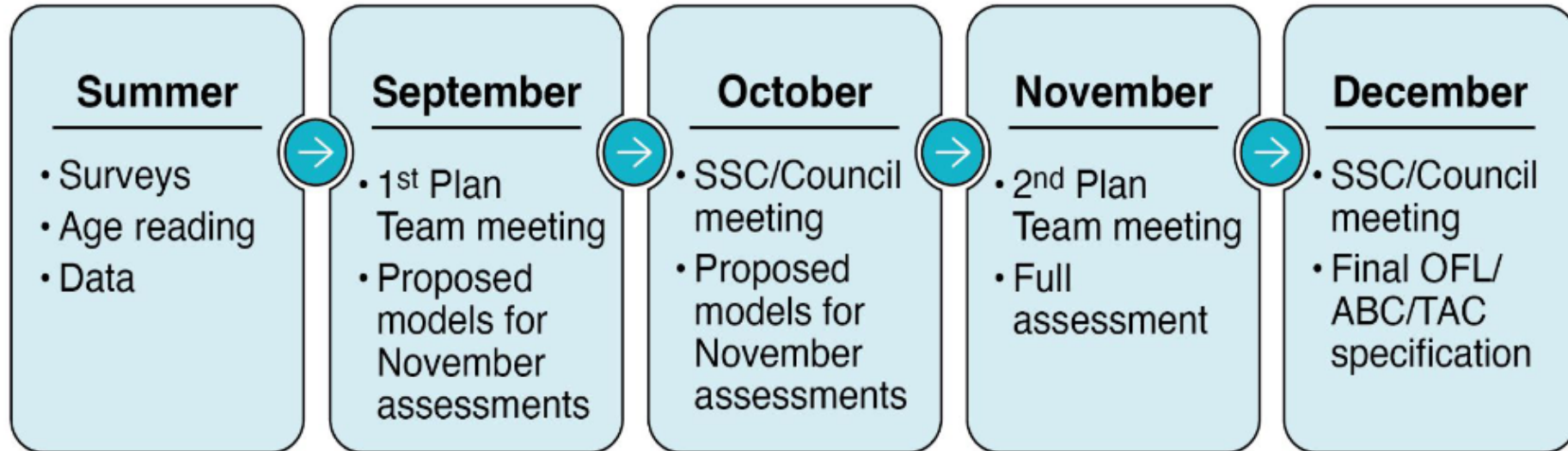
Automatic rebuilding below $B_{40\%}$



Annual Harvest Specifications Process: Science to management



Annual Schedule for Assessment Review



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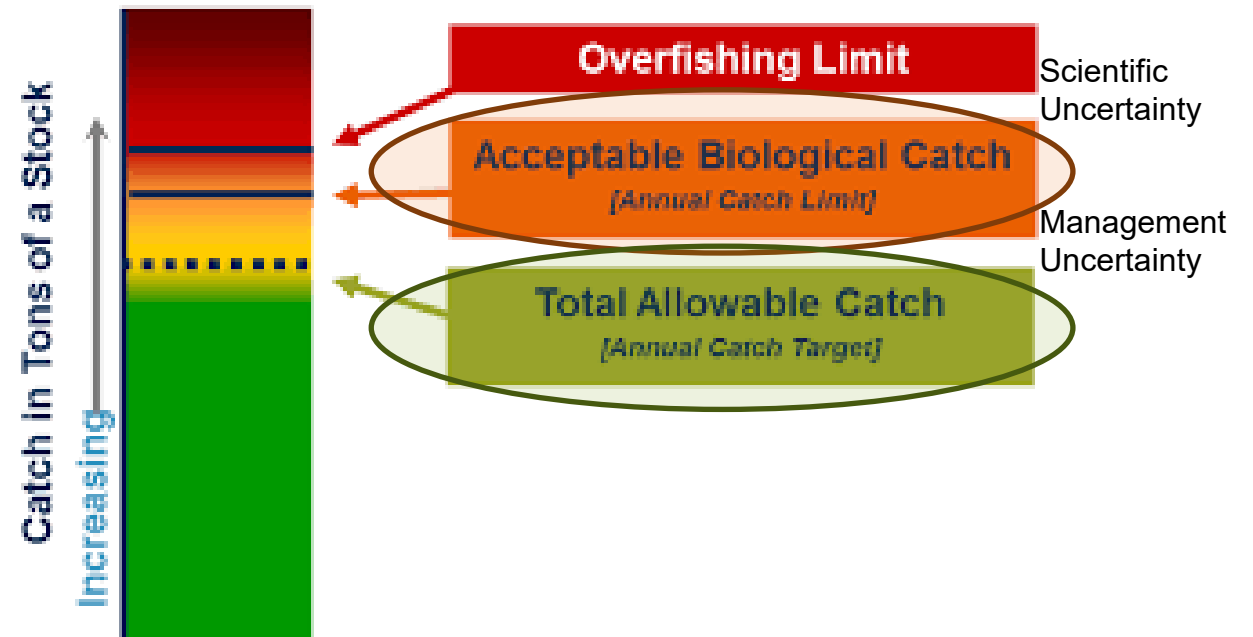
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Distribution of ABC spatially across regions

Whale Adjusted Catch Tables by Region

Year	2024				2025		2026	
Region	OFL _w	ABC _w	TAC	Catch*	OFL _w	ABC _w **	OFL _w	ABC _w **
BS	--	11,450	7,996	3,940	--	13,898	--	13,723
AI	--	13,100	8,440	1,266	--	12,175	--	12,022
GOA	--	22,596	22,596	13,406	--	24,038	--	23,737
WGOA	--	4,699	4,699	2,101	--	4,996	--	4,934
CGOA	--	9,651	9,651	5,655	--	10,257	--	10,128
**WY	--	2,926	2,926	2,172	--	3,125	--	3,086
** SEO	--	5,320	5,320	3,478	--	5,660	--	5,589
Total	55,084	47,146	39,032	18,612	58,532	50,111	57,797	49,482

* As of October 10, 2024 Alaska Fisheries Information Network, (www.akfin.org).

** After 95:5 trawl split shown above and after whale depredation methods described above.

Courtesy of Dan Goethel

TAC Allocations: Gulf of Alaska

Western GOA TAC

80% fixed gear

- hook & line
- pot gear
- (& jig)

20% trawl gear

Central GOA TAC

80% fixed gear

- hook & line
- pot gear

20% trawl gear

Eastern GOA TAC

95 % fixed gear

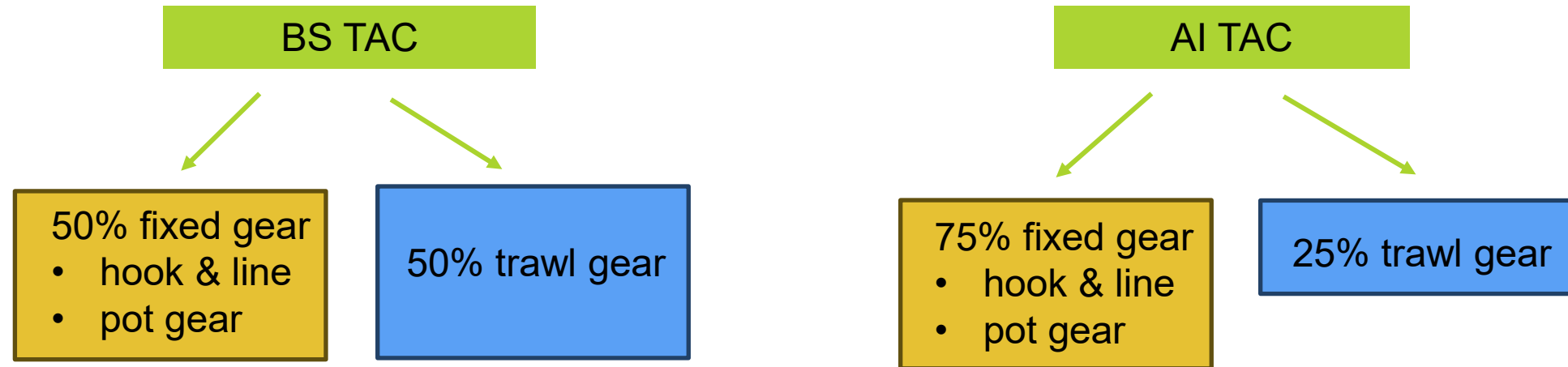
5% trawl gear

Southeast
Outside (SEO)

West Yakutat



TAC Allocations: BSAI



Further allocations to CDQ, non-specified reserve, ITAC

Allocations: Management Programs

- **Individual Fishing Quota (IFQ) Program- 1995**
 - Individual IFQ is determined annually, ratio of QS to the area quota share pool and the area-specific TAC
 - Fixed gear only
 - By management area
 - Based on vessel categories (A, B, C, D) - size
 - Season March-Nov
 - Largely mandatory retention (few exceptions)
- **Community Development Quota (CDQ) Program (BSAI only)**
 - western Alaska communities
- **Incidental catch in other fisheries (all gear types)**





Recent Council actions, economics

- Whale depredation → Action to allow use of pot gear, slinky pots
 - Price and markets sensitive to size of fish
 - Volume of small fish has flooded market
 - Low prices
- }
- Action to allow release of small sablefish IFQ/CDQ
 - Fixed gear fleet more recently asking for lower TACs



QUESTIONS?

